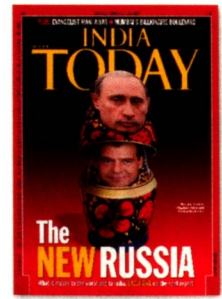


AFF



"The New Russia",
May 19, 2008

**"Combining
communism and
pragmatism, Vladimir
Putin has made Russia
an economic and
political force to
reckon with."**

GAGAN SHARGA, on e-mail

Putting Faith in Putin

Kudos is due to your cover story for having presented a fine picture of how Vladimir Putin turned around a nation that was facing its worst economic crisis ("The New Russia", May 19). We should learn innovation and invention from them to reduce our dependence on oil imports. We must expand our trade with Russia beyond the traditional items.

A. JACOB SAHAYAM,
Thiruvananthapuram

The cover story was enlightening. Although our country has its own checks and balances, can't our leaders resolve to fight against horrendous corruption at each and every level of the system? I suggest they take this story as a cue and lead our country to super status.

INDU SHANKAR, Varanasi

That Vladimir Putin, an un-

known and uncertain entity barely a decade ago, is the most famous Russian today is indisputable. That he yearns for a permanent place in history is no secret—Peter the Great being his role model. If he continues showing miracles the way he has done in the past, he will soon find himself sitting on the highest firmament of Russian glory. But, a failure can initiate all kinds of post-mortem.

AMITABH THAKUR, Lucknow

Though there are people who have started raising doubts on the efficacy of the two-headed political structure in Russia, it would seemingly prove more like the continuation of the old system with Medvedev being present more as a titular head. In fact, it resembles the Sonia-Manmohan model that has worked so well in India.

DR NUTAN THAKUR, Lucknow

INDIA TODAY deserves rich compliments for writing a cover story on a changing Russia. With India's high technical competence the time is right to support the developmental process of Russia with lucrative advantage. Any delay in the matter can prove detrimental to our economic interests.

VIRENDRA K. TANGRI, on e-mail

One Man Army

Mani Shankar Aiyar's valiant efforts to provide momentum to Panchayati Raj notwithstanding, the system will not succeed unless the elected members are educated or trained in rural-centric issues of public administration ("One Man Mission," May 19). Giving them quasi-judicial and financial powers without ridding them of social and economic prejudices may result in misuse of opportunity.

Y.G. CHOUKSEY, Pune

The magazine deserves all praise for selecting a superb title for an excellent story on Panchayati Raj and projecting rural issues prominently. It is apparent that the Ministry of Panchayati Raj has taken rapid strides and achieved a lot under the leadership of an enthusiastic and people-friendly Union minister. I congratulate him.

ANJANI K. TIWARI, Motihari

A Different Market

Malls are very useful in today's times for those who don't have much time and can't afford to go to many places to pick up things ("Mall Entrepreneurs", May 19). Everything is available in a very systematic manner and on a good platform in malls for designers to showcase their designs.

MAHESH K. DADRWAL, Jaipur

Watch Your Words

Your columnist's question why political leaders never